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'Where is the friend's house?': Intimacy, Spatiality, and (post-)Ottoman Legacies in Sait Faik Abasıyanık

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ABSTRACT
What follows is a discussion of *There's a Snake in Alemdağ* (*'Alemdağ'da Var Bir Yılan'*), the 1954 collection of short stories by the Turkish author Sait Faik Abasıyanık. *Alemdağ*, the final addition to Abasıyanık's celebrated literary career, is shaped by its author's unprecedented openness about homoerotic desire and intimacy, and the book represents one of the earliest examples of what may be called 'queer literature' in modern Turkey. I am concerned here primarily with two aspects of Abasıyanık's project that seem to have escaped scholarly notice so far: Firstly, I draw attention to the connections between Abasıyanık's conception of queer being and desire in 1950s Istanbul and traditional Ottoman literary modes of desire and intimacy between males. Secondly, I perform a close reading of the book's central narrative to show how spatiality – as it unfolds in the tangible urban, domestic, and natural environments in and around Istanbul – is central to Abasıyanık's understanding, and representation, of queer being, desire, and intimacy.

KEYWORDS
Turkish literature; homoeroticism; eros; spatial theory; Ottoman history

Introduction: Towards a spatial dialectic

> The alley of the friend is the place of freedom, that is, the place of the freedom of the soul, an arena in which the soul finds itself free. Man, however, is of the world: He comes into the world, spends time in the world, and lives within its time. His soul and body travel in the world, and the world travels within his soul and body. The human who has fallen into the world hurls himself beyond the corrosive revolving of the world to the alley of the friend in order to free himself from the enslavement of its inevitable laws. This same enslavement drives him towards freedom. — Shahrokh Meskoob, *In the Alley of the Friend* (2018, 93)

> A space must be maintained or desire ends. — Anne Carson, *Eros the Bittersweet* (1986, 26)

In his recent 'The Dialectic of Space: An Untimely Proposal', Andrew Cole critiques what he sees as a commonplace inattention to space and problems of spatiality in thinking about ideology – and, more widely, in thinking *per se* – and the resulting relinquishment of space and spatiality as rich and fundamental foundations of critical engagement. Cole, arguing that 'ideology tells us it has space covered precisely because it doesn't' (2020, 812), calls for scholars to 'test for ideology's allergies' by pitting the media of language

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and time (where ideology, he argues, is at home) against those of space and matter (where he argues that it isn't). At its heart, Cole's is an invitation to attend to the ways in which matter and space 'code' meaning and experience differently from language and time; and what I offer here will be a reading of Sait Faik Abasıyanık's *There's a Snake in Alemdağ* (*Alemdağ'da Var Bir Yılan*) meant precisely to pursue the author's dialectical fleshing out of the experience of queer being and intimacy in 1950s Istanbul in, and *as*, space and being-in-space. I am interested in capturing how in Abasıyanık 'space continually exceeds ideology, failing to conform to it' (Cole 2020, 812), but also often becomes the site where possibilities of queer being and intimacy which space itself inspires are later foreclosed — perhaps because ideology always gives chase and often catches up, frequently through the media of 'embodiment, desire, feelings and emotions' (813). It is this tug-of-war unfolding within space that, in my reading, forms a 'dialectic of queer space' in Abasıyanık — admittedly a shakier spatial dialectic than the one Cole calls and argues for, which is, at least aspirationally, invulnerable to the assaults and interceptions of ideology.

Fundamental to Cole's spatial dialectic, and he channels Sartre here, is the 'foundational' role of 'past praxes' in and of space to the present 'matter of our built environment', the 'activation' (Cole 2020, 817) of sedimented past and inertial spatial praxes through engagement in the present. I share this concern, and focus below on Abasıyanık's reactivation of the classical Ottoman – and, in its roots, Persio-Hellenic – socio-literary mode and construct of male homoeroticism centered around the notion of transcendental intimacy between two males in constructing a modern articulation of space, spatiality, and queer being.

Ultimately, my reading is guided by the desire to explore 'just where the built environment, redolent with its past praxes, resides in social life … and … just where and what social life fundamentally "is"' (Cole 2020, 820) in the queer lifeworld sketched by Abasıyanık. Much of my reading is an attempt to respond to Cole's argument that the methodology of such an exploration – of a spatial dialectic – is one that requires us to 'see two things at once, in the same space' (824) and to attend to the 'material contradictions' always present in space. We'll return to this curious double-vision, and what Cole, in his reading and incorporation of Hegel, calls 'the strange contradiction that "at the same time" a thing is "here and not here"' (825), which drives much of *Alemdağ*'s spatial dialectic, shortly.

Before delving into a discussion of Ottoman male homoeroticism and a spatial reading of *Alemdağ*, a more detailed introduction to the book is in order. Ostensibly a collection of short stories, Abasıyanık's final book in fact intertwines standalone short stories with the longer, fragmented auto-fictive narrative of one homoerotic duo: A narrator named İshak – himself a Turkish writer and a tender, lovelorn Istanbul *flaneur*; a transparent continuation of the highly autobiographical narratorial persona that bridges Abasıyanık's oeuvre – and Panco (from the Greek 'Panagiotis'), his much younger 'friend' and romantic interest, a member of Istanbul's belaguered Greek minority.[1] Often surrealistic, sometimes dreamlike narratives that are part of the İshak-Panco storyline open and conclude the book, and fragments of their story, centring questions of queer being and desire,

[1]For earlier - though surprisingly recent - acknowledgements of the work as an example of 'queer literature', see Güven 2010; Maksudyan 2019; Rifat 2020.

re-surface in some of the standalone stories in between. The standalone stories without queer content, which I lack the space to discuss at length here, themselves arguably point back to the dreamlike, highly romanticised İshak-Panco narrative precisely by their stark contrast with it: Nearly every single one of these explores a heterosexual coupling shaped by moral and emotional dearth, often intertwining and condemning what Abasıyanık sees as conventional modes of morality, emotionally bankrupt partnerships, and rampant materialism. Strikingly, the standard representation of heterosexual relationality across *Alemdağ* (though an explicit argument to this effect is never made) is one doomed to hypocrisy and marred by materialist greed. In the emotionally dour, pragmatic world of these 'heterosexual' stories, romantic commitments are maintained only as long as they make socioeconomic sense, often only until a 'upgrade' of sorts becomes available. This world's interruptions of (and interruptions by) the narrative that unfolds between Panco and the author-narrator İshak emphasise the dreamlike, often surrealist texture and the emotional profoundness of the latter, socioculturally unacceptable queer romance. Arguably, then, Abasıyanık's formal organisation of the book itself creates a tangible textual spatiality that affirms – without ever asserting – the possibility and value of queer desire, intimacy, and being; as well as performing, in the material space that is the book, a socioculturally disruptive praxis of queer being and longing.

Enter 'the beloved': On the Ottoman (and pre-Ottoman) roots of Abasıyanık's queer Istanbul

As I mentioned above, and perhaps surprisingly for a book written in mid-twentieth century Turkey, Abasıyanık's portrayal of love and intimacy between men throughout *Alemdağ'da Var Bir Yılan* closely approximates the classical Ottoman literary-cultural construct of intense passion and (often transcendental) intimacy between males. To be specific, I refer to the constellation of an older 'lover' and a younger 'beloved', respectively called *âşık* and *mahbûb* in the Ottoman tradition (the latter often referred to as *dōst* دوست, *friend*, especially in Persian poetry) approximating closely the Ancient Greek *erastes* and *eromenos.*[2] Given its centrality to my discussion of Abasıyanık, a discussion of the specifics – and the evolving scholarly reception and understanding – of the *âşık-mahbûb* pairing is in order.

As one scholar puts it succinctly, '[e]arly modern Ottoman poetry is predominantly about love; and for the most part, both the subject and the object of this love are men' (Arvas 2014, 145) — though the term 'men' here comes with a caveat, as the male *recipient* of a poetic narrator's love, that is, the *mahbûb,* was nearly always understood to be a prepubescent (or early pubescent) *boy*, with romance and sex between adult males highly frowned upon. (Though exceptions, even in the highest echelons of Ottoman poetry such as in the work of the early eighteenth century poet Nedim, offering the 'image of the beloved as adult man', are not infrequent (Arvas 2014, 151).) In this sense, and as we'll explore further, the *âşık-mahbûb* literary construct did not merely signify aesthetic taste but significantly intertwined the erotic and the socio-political: The narrative norm, in this tradition, of the performative powerlessness of the *âşık* in the throes of his love for

[2]See, for a rare attempt at evaluating the Ancient Greek and classical Persian socio-literary constructs of the boy beloved side by side and as part of a larger (if at times overtly Orientalistic) global comparative framework, Burton (1886).

a (performatively exalted, often all-powerful and thus, over his lover, sultanic) *mahbûb,* as Andrews and Kalpaklı have definitely shown, served as a coda for hierarchies of power and patronage in the elite milieu that produced and consumed this poetry (Andrews and Kalpaklı 2015). On a related note, the *âşık-mahbûb* literary construct intertwined the erotic and the mystical: the love and desire towards union with the *mahbûb* had strong allegorical connotations for love of, and desire for transcendental union with the all-powerful that is, God. Indeed, very often, more important than any physical consummation of desire in a *ghazal* was the process by which the 'beloved became the metaphorical bridge to achieve the true love of God' (Kuru 2020a, 44). Nevertheless, the growing significance to this intensely political and spiritual poetic tradition of real human beloveds – not infrequently mentioned by name (Kuru 2006) – should not be overlooked.

This Ottoman literary-social construct of homoeroticism between *âşık* and *mahbûb* began to dissolve in the nineteenth century as Ottoman reformers and intellectuals came to adopt – or at least adapt to – the Western critics of such 'perversion'-laden intimacy (and, in Andrews and Kalpaklı's argument (Andrews and Kalpaklı 2015), as the sociopolitical networks and power relations that inspired and sustained the Ottoman hierarchies that found their expression in the *âşık-mahbûb* model dissipated). As Ottoman – and later, Republican Turkish – elites bought into Western discourses of a normative 'heterosexuality' and a perverse, despicable 'homosexuality' to be suppressed, scholarly and critical receptions of the classical Ottoman literary mode of homoerotic relationality became increasingly uncomfortable. Seeking to suppress either the significance or the 'nativeness' of such intimacies, scholars of the early and mid-twentieth century – not that such denialism is entirely extinct today – adopted a number of strategies: Some argued that classical Ottoman poetry was *entirely* metaphorical and spoke only of mystical love in its treatment of male beloveds, some (stretching an argument from the gender neutrality of Turkish pronouns) that all Ottoman literary beloveds were in fact female, while others minimised the romantic or erotic content of male poets' appreciations of male beauty or, acknowledging a 'perverted' homoerotic sensual potency of classical Ottoman poetry, argued that such desires and expressions were fundamentally alien Greco-Persian imports to (and corruptions of) the Ottomans, or spoke to the 'perverted' nature of an Ottoman culture itself argued to be fundamentally alien to a modern Turkish identity and literature (Sarıtaş 2020; Seyfeddin 1911).

More recent – and less one-dimensional – interpretations of the normative Ottoman and Islamicate literary-social constructs of male-to-male intimacy – often with an eye towards cultural specificities such as the contradiction between its literary acceptance and the harsh legal and discursive rejection of actual sexual intimacy between adult men – developed in tandem with scholarly work that argued for more spacious and specific analysis of the larger Ottoman and Islamicate understandings and regimes of gender and sexuality. Influential monographs by Khaled El-Rouayheb and Dror Ze'evi explored discourses of sexuality and gender in the pre-modern Middle East and questioned the applicability of Western labels such as (and the linear opposition between) 'homosexuality' or 'heterosexuality' to an Islamicate context (El-Rouayheb 2015, Ze'evi, 2006). Arguably as part of the same scholarly trend and with the *mahbûb-âşık* constellation in mind, Leslie Peirce has suggested in the Ottoman case that '[g]ender identity continually transformed itself over the course of one's lifespan by associating

different normative behaviors with each phase in the life cycle' (1997, 169) and has pointed out the unique significance of the 'socio-sexual hierarchies' based on class as well as urban/rural origin to Ottoman sexualities (2009, 1333). In a culmination of this approach, Irvin Cemil Schick has argued that in the Ottoman case:

> one can speak of three genders and two sexualities. First, rather than a male/female dichotomy, sources clearly view men, women and boys as three distinct genders … rather than a hetero/homosexual dichotomy, the two sexualities are defined by penetrating and being penetrated. (2018 (online); see also Schick 2004; 2020)

An attendant argument has thus been that in this historical context, pre-pubescent and pubescent males – the 'boy-beloveds' that fulfilled the role of the 'beloved' in the Ottoman 'spectrum of sociosexual roles' – were 'neither male nor female in the modern sense' (Sayers 2017, 221, 223).

This scholarly push for a more culturally- and historically-specific understanding of the *mahbûb-âşık* construct as well as Ottoman understandings of gender notwithstanding, a number of scholars have also continued to see 'homoerotic desire' and 'love' (Kuru 2020a, 58–59) and 'male homoeroticism' (Sarıtaş 2020, 88–111) be it toward a boy or a man, as fundamental to pre-modern Ottoman literature, arguably representative of a 'conspicuous homoeroticism amongst Ottoman learned man' (Kuru 2006). In fact, Delice offers an important corrective to what he perceives as a trend towards excessive deconstructionism in recent problematisations of Ottoman sexuality and gender, arguing that such an approach 'works at the expense of the ways in which historical narratives did identify individuals, perhaps not in accordance with their sexual preferences, but certainly in keeping with their manners, identifications, styles, gender self-presentations, and forms of subjectivity that were not entirely unrelated to their sexual preferences and acts' (2010, 118).[3] He argues that the 'queer others of the Ottoman past' often do constitute 'a dissident type, coterie, and identity' (2015, 117), and elsewhere offers passionate, intimate 'friendship' as a useful framework within which to perceive the Ottoman practice and ethics of 'same-sex intimacy' (2010, 123). Indeed, a succinct, and, for our purposes, important recent scholarly characterisation of homoerotic intimacy in the classical Ottoman literary mode (and one that is strikingly evocative of the sort of Platonic homoeroticism one finds in the Symposium) has been that of a coterie of 'male individuals who realise love in the form of true friendship with another male' (Kuru 2020b, 141).

As important as this historical background for our purposes is the question of *how* the classical Ottoman *âşık-mahbûb* romance operated — the question of the normative tropes that determined the relationality between the two figures, many of which I find to be closely approximated in the İshak-Panco romance of *There's a Snake in Alemdağ*. To begin with and as mentioned above, the *mahbûb* of the classical poetic formulation is longed for and exalted by an older man in the throes of a passionate, devouring, near-divine, *total* love; or, as the Ottoman poet Nâbî puts it, 'Like a crucible, the heart is warmed in the fire of separation' ('Olup dil bûte gibi tâb-ı hicrân ile germ-ülfet') (Andrews, Black, and Kalpaklı 2006, 114, 293). In the analysis of one scholar, what we

[3]Arvas (2014) also importantly draws attention to literary instances where the 'penetrated – penetrator' and 'boy – adult male' dichotomies do not neatly map onto each other and, more generally, speaks of the Ottoman literary tradition in terms of predominant 'same-sex desire' and 'same-sex male eroticism'

have in hand in the *âşık* is 'a male lover who worships the male beloved. Such poetry lavishes attention on the weaknesses of this male lover, his tears, his total demasculinization (though arguably not effeminization)' (Kuru 2020b, 143). Importantly, however, this 'constantly crying rebel lover', who is 'in a sense emasculated … is also empowered in that his yearning for ultimate union with the beloved enables him to deny the material world and all the obligations his status required' (Kuru 2023, 74). The heart of the *âşık*, then, is indeed a crucible; but it is 'warmed' and expanded by love. As we'll see below, Abasıyanık's protagonist very much assumes this positionality of an *âşık* overwhelmed by the totality and bewilderment of his love for a *mahbûb*, entirely powerless before the latter but also empowered, through his enduring love for him, to cast away what he perceives as the banal conventionalities of life and love in mid-century Istanbul.

Importantly, the all-consuming *âşık-mahbûb* relationality often unfolds spatially in the classical tradition, with a narrator-*âşık*'s often peripatetic or spatial pursuit or frantic circumambulation (or at other times bewildered awaiting) of the beloved represented as ceaseless and debilitating. A common metaphor is that of the moth circling – and eventually flying into – a candle, and, drawing from the Islamicate legend of Mejnun the crazed *âşık*-wanderer, '[t]he lover', in the tradition, 'is generally depicted as a strange, solitary person who finds himself in the desert, sleeps and wakes in the wilderness, his state is significantly different from the accepted societal norms' (Andrews 2000a, 147–148), and his peripatetic mode 'represents … errand-ness … against settledness' (Andrews 2000b, 124). In the words of the Ottoman poet Fuzûlî:

> Hiç meskende karârum yokdurur ol zevkden
> Kim kaçan hâk-i ser-i küyun ola mesken mana
>
> The pleasure of wondering when I will be near you
> Keeps me from calling any place my home (Andrews, Black, and Kalpaklı 2006, 77, 283)

Despite this state of constant searching and yearning, however, the classical Ottoman lyric tradition is one where moments of union and privacy are sporadic, at times hardly distinguishable from a Platonic ideal, and are often recalled or imagined as dramatic ruptures of longing. (On the 'beloved', his attributes, and his sociocultural place in Ottoman history and literature as discussed here, Andrews 2000a; Delice 2012; El-Rouayheb 2015; Landry 2014). This is a trope with ancient roots — 'the pain of absent presence' and 'pursuit and flight (as) a *topos*' were essential to the Ancient Greek conception of *eros* (Carson 1986, 18–19), and Shahrokh Meskoob, in the quote that opens this paper, speaks strongly to an adjacent conception of love as a constant peripatetic and rare – indeed Platonic – arrival in the classical Persian tradition. *Alemdağ*'s narrator experiences his relationship to Panco in precisely such terms, and Abasıyanık maintains constant, intimate tension between rare (re)union and ravishing pursuit/expectation:

> I'd go insane when he came [home] late. I'd go rabid when I realised the footsteps on the stairs were someone else's. Then suddenly, his footsteps. I would have left the door open. He'd come as if from another planet. I'd kiss his eyes.
>
> Must get out. Must get out of here too. The cinema is closing. I must walk the streets, carrying on my back my luck, my self. Must see neighborhoods. See houses … Must sit on the rabble and watch this house … until the neighborhood watchman arrives. (Abasıyanık [1954] 2024, 20)

Interchanges of ravishing longing and uncertain, fleeting moments of union thus characterise the relationship to the male beloved in *Alemdağ*. Frequently after such rare moments of union, and as exemplified above, Abasıyanık throws his narrator back onto the street — and, to channel Kiarostami, into an ever-renewed search for the friend's house, for the friend's alley. In this way, the longing for the beloved creates a distinctly queer flaneur-narrator. Or, to revisit an Ottoman poet I quoted earlier, 'For so long Nâbî has been coming and going from this quarter-crazed/And not once has that beloved asked, "What does this man desire?"' ('Bir gün dimez o şûh ki ayâ murâdı ne/ Çokdan bu kûye Nâbî-i şeydâ gelür gider') (Andrews, Black, and Kalpaklı 2006, 116, 294) — we'll return shortly to Nâbî's point on the indifference of the *mahbûb* to the *âşık*'s suffering and peregrination, which is similarly reproduced in Abasıyanık.

Before then, two other points in the passage above from *Alemdağ* are of note: The figure therein of the watchman – evoked alternately as a sentry, guardian, caravan herder or rival – is itself a common trope and a frequently-met, spatialised disruptor of the search for intimacy with the beloved in Ottoman – and, more generally Islamicate, especially classical Persian – poetry (Andrews, Black, and Kalpaklı 2006, 175). The evocation of a cinema, just one example of constant presentations throughout *Alemdağ* of movie theatres, theatres, *meyhane*s, and *kahvehane*s as (oftentimes *the*) spaces of queer sociability and longing, also strongly evokes the crucial role ascribed to taverns and coffeehouses in the literary articulation and worldly experience of Ottoman homoeroticisms and homosociality (Kaynar 2014; Koçu 1968, esp. 4639–4640; Sarıtaş 2020). Abasıyanık witnesses and affirms a continued queer lifeworld of Istanbul *meyhane*s (traditional pubs) and *kahvehane*s (coffee houses), an urban queer spatial configuration that has grown to incorporate the theatres and movie theatres of mid-century Istanbul. Both the limitations to and the facilitation of queer being and desire for Abasıyanık, then, take place in a historically grounded spatiality of homoeroticism and homosociality. Abasıyanık as such is tapping into and in fact reactivating, in the mode of historico-spatial queer being and desire he offers in *Alemdağ*, what Cole foregrounds as,

> the matter of our built environment, as itself a production: concretised labor and human effort called praxis. Our surroundings are layered with these past praxes, these past forms of life. They are not buried. But they are foundational. What's sedimented into our built environment lingers there as passivities that are activated every time we engage them. (2020, 817)

The space of modern urban Istanbul in Abasıyanık is one defined by classical Ottoman praxes of homoeroticism, and *Alemdağ* itself revives the passivities left behind by that concrete historico-spatial legacy.

To return to the figure of the beloved, another critical aspect of this cultural-literary construct finds strong salience throughout *Alemdağ*, all the way until the narrative's very final moments. In Ottoman poetry, a narrator's love for the male beloved – the *mahbûb* – accompanies a performative reversal of power hierarchies, with a once-powerful or once-respectable narrator often languishing or falling to disrepute under a despotic youth, whose power, paradoxically enough, stems from a narrator's passion for him — and from his heavily stylised boyish beauty. (In this, too, the Ottoman tradition offers a continuation of the Ancient Greek and classical Persian homoerotic traditions — 'Sappho begins with a sweet apple and ends in infinite hunger' (Carson 1986, 29).)

The classical Ottoman beloved, much like the Hafezian *saqi* who passes by in infinite grace to intoxicate and bewilder but lingers rarely, is a cruel lover: The continuity of his interest in, or tenderness towards, the narrator is never certain, and demands on his time and affections often result in assertions of his autonomy and self-sufficiency. Abasıyanık, once again, takes his cue – intentionally or not – from the classical tradition: '"Will I not see you again?" I said. He got angry. "That's for me to know", he said' ([1954] 2024, 14). 'He is being dour. He doesn't talk at all. He doesn't make a single sound. Then I sweat as if I've entered a burning hot room full of steam. Then it snows on me, it snows' (19). This dramatic surrender of power and authority – including over one's corporeal well-being – accompanies a near-obsessive desire on the part of the narrator for physical nearness to the beloved:

> He hadn't taken off his fur-lined coat. The fur was still cool. He had pressed his scarred cheek against the coolness. The fur's lips were kissing him. He started. He had remembered me. He lurched … .When he lied next to me on summer days I'd fall into a sound sleep. I'd dream of nothing. Nothing. Is there anything as beautiful as nothing? (20)

Love as longed-for oblivion, as the only path to the individual's dissolution in the Absolute, of course, is itself a central tenet of Islamic mysticism and the classical Ottoman tradition of mystical-homoerotic poetry: As the sixteenth century Ottoman poet (and Sheikh-ul Islam) Yahya calls to his beloved: 'Destroy the dwelling of the heart, don't leave a single stone standing on a stone' ('Dil-hânesini yık koma taş üstüne bir taş/Sen yap anı eller ana vîrâne desinler') (Andrews, Black, and Kalpaklı 2006, 104, 291).

Having argued for Abasıyanık's multifaceted appropriation of the classical Ottoman – and, embedded within that, classical Greek and Persian – literary structures of desire and homoeroticism, in the close reading of *Alemdağ* that follows, I refer to Panco often as the 'beloved'. I am particularly interested in fleeting moments of togetherness between Panco and İshak, and the ensuing losses of intimacy as these unfold in (and as I will show, often *as*) space. My argument is that an uneasy dialectic of queer space (and of queer being-in-space) emerges out of such moments; and that in a work of thoroughly confounded temporality, space takes the centre stage in any elaboration of identity and difference.

There's a Snake In Alemdağ: A spatial reading

Cole's spatial dialectic is one 'activated by those who work it, walking the path, moving the stone, designing and building the bridge' (2020, 820), and Abasıyanık relies most consistently on such 'walking the path' to narrate queerness. Indeed, queerness in *Alemdağ* is always queerness-in-space: İshak, the narrator of each of the İshak-Panco narratives barring one, is an Istanbul flaneur, moving in space almost obsessively from the very first sentences of the book: 'When I got out of the cinema the rain had started again. What will I do? I cursed. I craved a walk so much … ' (Abasıyanık [1954] 2024, 1). When he instead hops on a car to head to the distant neighorhood of Atikali (for no discernible reason at first — 'Would I go to Atikali at this time of night? I would') (Abasıyanık [1954] 2024, 1), he 'travels over hill and dale' (Abasıyanık [1954] 2024, 1), with Abasıyanık imparting a near-mythical or fairytale-like scale and texture to his narrator's peregrinations. Much of *Alemdağ* will follow in this vein, with the narrator crisscrossing

Istanbul streets, flitting between the city's cinemas, beer gardens, and theatres, or taking refuge in private or natural spaces only to be flushed back onto the urban jungle. As I have already discussed, it is always a search for, a rendezvous with, or (the hope) of a run-in with the young male beloved that motivates and guides, as Cole puts it, the 'walking the path' of Abasıyanık's narrator. In turn, it is the experience of the meeting (or the missed encounter) with the beloved that overdetermines how the narrator experiences and narrates the space he moves through. In Cole's terms, it is the built (or at times, as we'll see, unbuilt, natural) environment that activates queer desire and thinking; and Abasıyanık's spaces are themselves activated around a core of queer personhood.

To return to the narrative that opens the book, Abasıyanık's narrator soon recalls – and longs for – 'my friend Panco … other than whom, for now, I have no one' (Abasıyanık [1954] 2024, 1) as he walks around and has a rather surreal series of encounters with a host of characters: A man named Hidayet who shrinks and hops into the narrator's pocket to tell him the tale of how he 'has killed his [intimate female] friend' (2), a man trapped in an unhappy marriage shouting 'Long live democracy! Long live the nation! Long live the republic!' (Abasıyanık [1954] 2024, 5) in the middle of the street, a young drunkard who speaks of his doomed affair with a Jewish woman and the menacing quietude of her husband when he catches the duo *in flagrante delicto* (Abasıyanık [1954] 2024, 11). After narrating their own stories, these figures make a request of the narrator: '"Tell Panco about me, won't you?"' (3), '"Oh, and tell Panco about me before you go to sleep … He's a good boy, Panco. A sweetheart, really. Say hi to him from me"' (7). The characters, importantly, make their abrupt demand that their stories be conveyed to Panco despite the narrator never having mentioned Panco to them. Their insistence that the narrator tell Panco about his movements and encounters in space is an externalisation of the narrator's (and arguably the author's) own conceptualisation of the relationship between 'walking the path' and Abasıyanık's queer beloved: The streets and districts of Istanbul must be crisscrossed and its inhabitants and their (dysfunctional) heterosexual romances be heard and thought about with the express purpose that these are then turned into a narrative for the queer beloved. A curious dialectic is already in play here: Even as Istanbul's urban and human landscape seems to churn out one dysfunctional heterosexual romance after another and sets them on the queer flaneur-narrator's path, for Abasıyanık this landscape is worth navigating, and narrating, but/and always in service of a non-normative queer intimacy. The closing page of the first narrative importantly introduces the reader to the darker underbelly, the fundamental contradiction, of this dialectic: Heeding the demands his interlocutors, the flaneur-narrator once again crosses the Golden Horn, walking up to Panco's doorstep across the city:

> And so, Panco, I arrived at your neighbourhood … There was a broken amphora right at your doorstep, half of it in tiny pieces, half of it completely intact. I sat inside the amphora. I began narrating how I went to Atikalipaşa in the middle of the night, how Hidayet got into my pocket, the man sleeping in the Fatih Park, the stray dog, the Jewish woman and the lecher. You were asleep. I called out: 'Hey, Panco, Panco!' My voice pierced through a window. It went and found your ear. You woke up. But I had no voice, I was in no condition to talk to you now. And you fell asleep again. A car was passing. 'Are you going to Bomonti?' I asked the driver. 'Jump in,' he said. I jumped in. (10–11)

On the one hand, the narrator has, as the classical Ottoman poet Yenişehirli Avni put it, ' … come to take refuge in the dust of the beloved's door' ('Hâk-i der-i cânâna penâh itmege geldik') (Andrews, Black, and Kalpaklı 2006, 159, 306); on the other, space catches up with the queer narrator – the queer voice – that circumambulates it, finds inspiration in it, and, for a moment, even manages to 'pierce' its materiality. At the very moment that demands of queer flaneuring and narrativity are about to be fulfilled and the narrator and the beloved come to actual physical proximity, an improbability of queer communication and communion permeating Istanbul's built and social space reasserts itself, the voice and the energies of the narrator are extinguished, and the narrator is urged back into movement, sucked away from the beloved, carried away in space.

This pattern of urban space creating a continuous, frustrating push-and-pull between the narrator and his beloved Panco, inspiring and facilitating the search for intimacy and communication while, to channel Cole again, blocking the path, becomes a common one throughout the multiple narratives that constitute the İshak-Panco story. In the narrative that immediately follows the one I discuss above, the narrator and Panco share an intimate if melancholy moment in a beer hall only to 'suddenly lose' (Abasıyanık [1954] 2024, 16) one another in the urban grid immediately upon stepping out onto the street. When, in a dreamlike turn, the narrator manages to find Panco again, the latter is joined by three other men, and takes no notice of the narrator. Unacknowledged by Panco and the others, the narrator is compelled to follow them around town, then into a cinema, then back onto the street. When Panco finally 'turns and looks' at the narrator, 'he didn't recognise (me). It was as if he was *looking at a stone, at a wall*' (17) (emphasis mine).

How to interpret this intensely spatial sequence? The semi-intimate space of the beer hall fosters an intimacy that, when it spills onto the public urban space, caves in to a surrealised anonymity and indifference, to a literal loss-in-space – and confused pursuit – of the beloved. Nevertheless, urban space is also what the desire to transcend the same indifference and loss-in-space is mapped onto, and arguably expressed *as*, as the narrator follows Panco around the city. In turn, the emotional dead-end at the end of the story is itself spatialised: Panco, finally taking notice of İshak, looks at him as if he were looking 'at a stone, at a wall'. In this explicit 'spatialization and materialization' (Cole 2020, 820) of the failure of a queer intimacy, the narrator, indeed, the *flaneur,* is reduced into a wall — into a roadblock. As I will show below, this is one of a number of instances where Abasıyanık chooses to *spatialise* emotion as opposed to expressing it merely in abstractions of language and time.

This wall-ification of İshak, however, is hardly the last we see of the narrator and his beloved Panco. Strikingly, the various narratives that make up their story are characterised by near-total absence of chronological sequentiality. If time unfolds across the narratives at all, it unfolds as movement through and across space. Thus, the intensely spatialised relationship between the narrator and Panco itself flows through space as opposed to time; and space itself is perceived and evaluated in connection to the possibilities it affords to intimacy between the narrator and Panco. Indeed, in the next, titular narrative of the collection, the loss-in-space and wall-ification I discussed above is followed by the tale of an extremely surrealistic,

near-Biblical queer idyll. The narrator and Panco are suddenly no longer in Istanbul but in the meadows of Alemdağ outside the city. I quote at length to delineate Abasıyanık's intensely spatial work here:

> Once again Istanbul is ugly. Istanbul? Istanbul is an ugly city. A dirty city … its bridges are covered in phlegm. Its side streets are muddy, full of rubble. And, at night, vomit everywhere. The houses have turned their backs to the sun. The streets are narrow. Its shopkeepers are cruel. Its rich are slackwits … To love: The beginning of all things is to love another. There [in Istanbul], you love another and everything ends.
>
> It's a beautiful place, a beautiful place, Alemdağ. These trees that go at fifteen kilometers an hour, its Taşdelen [River], its snake … The weather is warm in Alemdağ. The leaves of the sun are born inside the bright red trees. Something warm rains down from the sky, gathers on the rotten leaves. We play, we wrestle with … a rabbit, a snake, a blackbird, a partridge, a goat that ran away from Polonezköy to come here in our honor.
>
> A smile appears on Panco's face, which is otherwise always ashen, angry. He kisses the partridges on their beaks. He pulls on the rabbit's whiskers. He wraps the snake around his wrist. He has brought a ball … I am the goalkeeper. The snake is the goalkeeper too. The others lie on the leaves, play in the sun … Alemdağ, beautiful Alemdağ. İstanbul is covered in mud. (24–25)

I quote at length to emphasise the stark contrast Abasıyanık establishes between the built urban space of Istanbul and the *un*built, pastoral space of Alemdağ, and to show how this contrast is central to the latter's construction as a fairytale-like queer idyll. It is when one escapes the oppressive layers (one could say *heaps*, given all the phlegm and mud and rubble and vomit that join the houses that 'turned their backs to the sun') of built space and of being-in-space in Istanbul that love becomes a possibility, and this love, the 'beginning', rather than, as in Istanbul, the 'end' of all things, is strongly associated with a poetically-described natural space and with one's encounter with the nonhuman inhabitants of that space. Abasıyanık's dialectic of an urban space that inspires and facilitates queer longing and narration but makes impossible a true queer intimacy, a queer being-in-space *together* with the beloved, seems to be superseded or at least suspended in the flight to the unbuilt space of nature, itself strikingly similar to the meadows and pleasure gardens that are the idealised *topos* of homoerotic intimacy across the classical Perso-Ottoman poetic tradition, 'selective and exclusive' places admitting only beauty and where 'beauty, order, and usefulness reign without competition' (Andrews 2000a, 184–185; see also Andrews, Black, and Kalpaklı 2006, 33–34; Khansari, Moghtader, and Yavari 1998; Gharipour 2013).

'Those tulip-cheeked ones – o what they haven't dared do in the garden!' (Lâlehadler yine gülşende neler etmediler) (Andrews, Black, and Kalpaklı 2006, 275) the fifteenth century poet Necâtî asks in playful amazement, and he might as well be speaking of İshak and Panco. (Abasıyanık's repeated emphasis on the 'snake' of Alemdağ, given the animal's obvious association with Biblical paradise and with original sin, is also noteworthy). But if a natural/pastoral environment is conceptualised as one uniquely conducive to queer being and intimacy, what we have here is not a *resolution* of the spatial dialectic, or an undialectical solution to the problem of the built environment. Shortly after his description of a surreal idyll of the queer lovers and animals playing soccer by a riverside meadow, Abasıyanık takes us right back

to where we have started. Almost. Suddenly finding himself back in Istanbul, İshak is confused:

> When has Panco returned from Alemdağ? Suddenly he passes by me, a friend next to him. As if passing by a wall, or a dead cat. Our arms graze each other for a moment. Walls are torn open. People kiss one another as if they had had a fight and stopped talking for years, but finally had the same feeling, said 'Enough is enough,' and made up. I turn. Panco is still walking, laughing with his friend … (26)

and, after once again following Panco around the streets and into a coffeehouse, the narrator continues:

> … I never knew about the coffeehouse Panco went to with his friend … I pretended to look for someone … I saw Panco trying … not to show himself to me. I turned and looked as I left … I relaxed: I remembered the rabbit, the partridge, the … snake, Alemdağ, the Taşdelen River, the rotten leaves, the sun that softly rained down on the leaves. (26–27)

In other words, the respite brought about by environmental space cannot last, nature is not a fire escape from the dialectic, and the beloved is once again lost to the narrator, lost in an almost identical way as before (which is crucially a *spatial* before). But Abasıyanık shows us in this passage that the space outside of urban Istanbul – the pastoral/natural/un-built/queer space – is not entirely outside the dialectic, either. Going through the latter space changes the experience of built urban space and the connection between urban space and queer intimacy, taking the dialectic to its new stage: Unlike in the previous missed encounter, where there is no contact and the flaneur-narrator is wall-ified completely, the slightest of physical contacts is now allowed between the narrator and the beloved and as a result of this grazing of the arms 'walls are torn open', and some of the playful inter-species reconciliation is now carried over to the (previously despised) experience of the urban space and population of Istanbul. The experience of non-urban, natural space, it seems, has *opened up*, to a degree, the urban and human landspace of Istanbul to love and intimacy, and created the terms and instruments of endurance when those are absent. The dialectic is no longer at a walled-up impasse (even though it is unclear whether, in Cole's terms, some embedded aspect of Istanbul's built environment has been *activated* or, to the contrary, it has been *de-constructed*). Once again, and significantly, what we have at hand is not a 'happy ending' or an escape from the dialectic of urban space as Abasıyanık has thus far presented it: Panco still ignores and escapes the narrator in public space; but the narrator's experience of the natural environment, now very much a part of his being-in-space even in urban Istanbul (to expand one of Cole's terms, a spatial 'inertial praxis' (2020, 820) carried *across* spaces), now allows him a degree of joy and autonomy in navigating the urban queer dialectic. If, as Cole says, 'to participate in a collective is not to be a part. It is to be a whole', (Cole 2020, 820), I'd like to argue that Abasıyanık conceptualises human engagement with natural/environmental/un-built space and its inhabitants precisely as participation in a collective — the nonhuman inhabitants are spoken very much as a collective and a community, and it shouldn't be lost on us that animals, Panco, and the narrator form a literal soccer *team* in Alemdağ. Back in the urban space of Istanbul, the narrator still remains a part of this collective, and can continue to draw on the possibility of whole-ness it has so strongly offered.

A new narrative that begins immediately after the passage I quote above further expands Abasıyanık's vision of a productive infusion of the natural environment into the dialectic of queer urban space. In this narrative, titled 'Panco's Dream', Abasıyanık shifts the narratorial perspective from that of İshak to that of his beloved Panco for the first and only time in the book. We accompany Panco as he sleeps and wakes up in a working-class Greek home, thinks about his relationship to the flaneur-narrator, and interacts with his family. The narrative's opening offers an immediate *spatialised* aftermath, from Panco's perspective, to the idyllic intimacy on the meadows of Alemdağ:

> Something odd was taking place in (in the Turkish, *dönüyordu*; literally 'was turning/gyrating around') the house. The voices, the calls, the mealtimes, even faces were seemingly the same as always. Much better to have all the furniture change places, to have the voices muted, to have the mealtimes changed than this atmosphere (in the Turkish, *hava*; literally 'air' and metaphorically 'atmosphere' or 'mood') that fought even the being-in-the-same-place-as-always-ness of everything (*her şeyin her zamanki yerindeliğine bile karşı gelen hava*). Then one could wait for the tables and the glasses and the stools to really settle and remain in their place (in the Turkish, *yerinde yer etmesini*; literally, the items 'taking (or settling in) place in their place'). But no, everything was in the same place as always. ([1954] 2024, 29)

I see this difficult and rather cryptic passage as performing what Cole calls the '"material contradiction" at the center of the spatial dialectic', the 'strange contradiction', as he draws from Hegel, that 'a thing is "here and not here"' (828; he is quoting from Hegel [1812–1816] 2010, 382). Panco's room is 'here and not here': It is and is not as it has always been, it is in the *process* of changing, of battling – and thus slipping out of – its identity because its material same-ness can no longer contain what is 'taking place' in it, its 'atmosphere'. If, following Cole's argument, 'Hegel's whole aim is to challenge the long held belief that "the contradictory cannot … be represented or thought" and this must include the spatial contradiction of "what is here and not here"' (825; again quoting from Hegel [1812–1816] 2010, 382), Abasıyanık is arguably performing what Cole is calling for when he writes 'an impossibility like this … must be *represented* precisely because we lack the means to do so' (Cole 2020, 825). It is the experience – the ongoing dialectic – of queer being-in-space that produces for him a 'here and not here' as represented in this depiction of the space of Panco's room.

Like the scene where İshak is turned into a 'wall' by Panco's nonrecognition, Abasıyanık's narration of Panco's experience in his room takes place entirely in 'ideology's worst … most conceptually fraught media … matter and space' (Cole 2020, 812), rather than being confined to conceptual abstractions of language and time, 'ideology's best media' as Cole perceives them (812). The result is a subtle but materialised (to return to the passage above, literally space- and mind-shaking) laying out of what queer intimacy *does* in and to space and being-in-space. Abasıyanık's project, then, in eschewing time and abstraction in favour of spatialisation, becomes a 'critique of ideology' itself, and 'fosters constructive counter-hegemonic practices' (812), as Cole puts it, in this case practices of being queer and intimate in modern Istanbul. But I perhaps depart from Cole's interpretation on one important point: In his interpretation, 'consciousness and subjectivity' are media also strongly conducive to ideology, and 'ideology feels right at home' in 'embodiment, desire, feelings, and emotions, and more generally language itself' (815). What we see in the passage above, and has been the case to one extent or another in

all of the passages from Abasıyanık that I have examined, is that the binary (or at least the barrier) between spatiality/materiality and 'desire, feelings, and emotions' is not as strong as I understand Cole to suggest. An outpouring or a modification of queer 'desire, feelings, and emotions' very much *changes* the characters' tangible experience of material space: space itself is not impervious to modes – to the emotional and sexual charge – of being-in-space. To invoke Fanon, the bridge is perhaps a different bridge once the 'consciousness of those working on it' (or, in this case, *walking* it), is altered. It is through 'desire, feelings, and emotions' that Abasıyanık's citizens come to 'appropriate the bridge', or the room and the house and the city come to appropriate themselves. 'Then, and only then, is everything possible' (Cole 2020, 819; he is quoting Fanon [1963] 2003, 141).

In the same narrative, we are offered an account of another missed encounter between the narrator and his beloved in urban Istanbul; but this time from Panco's perspective, and in a dream. The passage brings to the fore Abasıyanık's spatialised concern with the 'here and not here', as well as the coexistence (arguably the melding together) of identity and non-identity in his spatial dialectic of queer intimacy:

> I had a dream last week. Two people were walking on a street. I likened one of them to you. I ran to see, wondering who it is that's walking next to you. How odd — wasn't it … me, walking next to you? 'Well, where are you going?' I said with my eyes. You didn't answer. I thought that there could be a me that is separate from me (*Ben benden ayrı bir ben olabileceğini … düşündüm*), and that this could only be possible in a dream. I wanted to say something. But the me that was next to you said: 'None of your business. We go where we please.' I wanted to answer. But although the me that wasn't me could speak, I couldn't. (Abasıyanık [1954] 2024, 31)

Later, awake, Panco heads out of his house alongside his father:

> We got out of the house together. We ran into you on the street. Where were you going so early? You looked at me so oddly that I laughed a lot after you disappeared in the distance. 'What are you laughing at?' my father asked. 'Nothing,' I replied. In truth, I was thinking of you. You were exactly like the me in my dream last night. But there was one difference. You hadn't run up to us and said: 'Where are you going, take me along' with your eyes. (33)

and shortly afterwards:

> I was happy. You had given me this joy. I loved everything twice, thrice as much now. You were the reason … I thought of you the moment I woke up in the morning. I laughed. I got up. I came here to you to tell you all this. What do you say? (33)

Thus queer being- and desiring-in-space brings to the fore the 'material contradictions' Cole discusses: Within the space of the missed encounters with the queer beloved, the self contains *both* the self and the beloved other, while *two* separate, materialised selves of the same subject exist and encounter one another in space, 'here and not here'. Panco, in the first, dreamt-of run-in with the flaneur-narrator, *is* and *is not* himself, he *can* and *cannot* speak. In turn, the encounter itself *is* and *is not* a dream: it takes place again, in a form that is not identical with itself but still clearly recognisable *as* itself, in waking life the next morning. I say 'not identical' because in the second run-in it is the narrator-flaneur who is now walking alone, he *is* and *is not* the solitary Panco of the dream. The moment of spatial encounter between the two characters serves as a point of puncture where identity and non-identity, narrator and beloved, self and

other are *one and not one*. Once again, Abasıyanık refuses to express this impossibility, this condition of queer intimacy and desire through abstraction, through language and time; but offers it within – indeed offers it *as* – spatialisation and materialisation. Significantly, as Panco *is* and *is not* the flaneur-narrator he encounters in space, earlier aspects of the dialectic are still in play: The second run-in in waking, 'real' urban space, unlike that in the space of the dream, remains one where the full expression of desire remains impossible. İshak cannot 'run up' to Panco as Panco ran up to İshak(-self) in the dream. Nevertheless, the notion of space and movement as experienced in service of and as facilitator in the search for queer intimacy is also still in place: Panco's final 'I came here to tell you all this' closely mirrors the narrator's compulsion in the book's first narrative to move in space *so that* space and its inhabitants can be narrated to, that they can be shared with – that the path can lead to – Panco.

After 'Panco's Dream', Abasıyanık lays aside the story of İshak and Panco for much of the book and, as I mention above, offers a number of standalone stories discussing failed hetero- and homoerotic intimacies. I lack the space here to analyse these; but one point of note is that they all involve spatial *escape*; notably to semi-private, semi-anonymous spaces such as beer halls, coffee houses, cinemas, and theatres in the case of queer or potentially queer characters. As I have already noted, this, in Cole's terms, is very much an authorial 'reactivation' of dormant 'sedimented praxes' (2020, 828) of homosociality and homoeroticism in the urban space of historical Istanbul. Such spatialisations allow Abasıyanık to avoid an explicit conceptualisation of queer relationality and desire even as they gently tilt the reading of otherwise ambiguous representations and relationships towards a queer one and thus 'open up a space within ideology, and outside it' (813) towards a transgressive but elusive representation of queer lifeworlds.

Abasıyanık undertakes a final elaboration of his dialectic of queer space, bringing together and exploring the tensions between urban, natural, private, and public spaces in the collection's highly surrealistic final narrative, which returns us to the story of İshak and Panco. Although the narrative's title, 'The Sleep of the Snake', evokes directly the events and characters of the earlier nature narrative in *There's a Snake in Alemdağ*, the narrator here is initially in the *second* person singular, and the beloved is initially ambiguous, including, thanks to the genderlessness of Turkish grammar, with regards to his or her gender:[4]

> There you are, face to face. S/he is just like you; has hands and feet, eyes and eyebrows, is healthy sick, blonde dark-haired (sic), has a head, has hair, eyelashes, a mouth that tells lies. Small scars on his/her face from fights, from stones thrown at him/her, from falls. All these markings of a naughty childhood, all small markings of it. His/her hands, fingers, feet, there. Who is this? Mankind! Just the same just as you (sic).
>
> …
>
> Just the same as you, different from everyone else. You want to take him inside your soul. There s/he is, reading the paper. There, practicing his/her signature on a cigarette pack. There, eating oranges … There, singing … sometimes in the Turkish you speak and that flows in your veins, 'Karabuberim buberim buberim!' … then [in Greek] 'Aspiya piluti

[4]This itself, of course, evokes the identical ambiguity borne out of a lack of grammatical gender – and often masterfully exploited – in speaking of the beloved in the classical Perso-Ottoman tradition.

> Keton Ibrahim!' … There you are, face to face. You can suddenly get up and kiss him/her on the lips. ([1954] 2024, 33)

The beloved as Abasıyanık conceptualises him/her here – all 'Mankind' *but* self-like *but* corporeally other, Turkish *and* Greek, only vaguely male, partially Panco (subtly but identifiably so — his 'small scars' are mentioned elsewhere in the book) and partially the narrator (singing in Turkish), a characterisation that destabilises once again the binary between identity and difference, between self and other, and offers a prime example of the kind of materialised 'here and not here' and the 'identical and not identical' that Cole foregrounds in Hegel as the source of a spatial dialectic. Beautifully performing this intertwinement are the inclusion of – and the free switching between – the Turkish *karabuberim buberim buberim* ('my black pepper, pepper, pepper') and the Greek *aspiya piluti Keton Ibrahim* («άσε πια τα πλούτη και τον Ιμπραήμ»; 'leave İbrahim and his wealth'), two lines drawn from the lyrics of the same traditional Greco-Turkish Constantinopolitan love song. Panco the Greek, then, *is* İshak the Turk, and they are *both* here, sitting face to face with the materialised self-other in a room, and they are both potentially 'Mankind'. This is the very 'total impossibility' that, as per Cole, Hegel is 'sloughing off' on us and that still 'must be *represented*'. For Abasıyanık, it is queer being and longing out of which this fundamental contradiction emerges, and it is through queer being and longing, as worked out dialectically in and through space, that this contradiction demands to be – and can be – represented.

'There you are, face to face. You can suddenly get up and kiss him on the lips'. But what is at hand is not a 'happy ending' to Abasıyanık's dialectic of queer space through the figure of the universalised self-other beloved. The spatialised precarity and uncertainty of queer being and intimacy that dominated many of the earlier narratives is soon introduced here also, and a series of surreal but spatial interruptions forestall a possible consummation:

> Suddenly the room of the door we were in swung open. The wind came in. A tree that had shed its leaves in the cold came in. After the tree, smoke came in, after the smoke, a bird came in, after the bird, a cloud came in. Then … then it started to snow. The glass windows of the bookshelf began to freeze over … The one sitting next to me had now gone into the next room. (116)

The narrator hurries to join the beloved in the next room — a bedroom: 'I cuddled up to him. So warm. Like a bathhouse'. But the bliss is incomplete: '"Where is the bird?" he asked. "In the tree", I said … "Bring the bird here! Bring the bird here!"' (116).

Heeding the beloved's call, the narrator hesitantly returns to the first room, now freezing cold even though a wood stove is burning, picks up the bird 'perched on the tree' *inside* the room, and returns to join the beloved — only to find that he has disappeared into thin air, leaving behind nothing but a blank sheet of paper (another call to narration?). But perhaps the beloved has left behind more than that:

> I left the bird on the nightstand. It began chirping. This room was still so warm. Still the curve of his lip and the thin hairless boyhood scar on his eyebrow were falling on my head like paper planes children make and throw around in class. (117)

Immediately after, a curt, anonymous man reminiscent of a Kafka bureaucrat bursts into the house and demands to know the whereabouts of the beloved. When the narrator

replies that he is unsure but thinks that he has left, the anonymous man checks under the blanket — and finds the beloved there once more!

The bureaucrat then accuses the narrator of lying and angrily demands an explanation. The latter instead steps away into the bedroom for a moment – 'to put on my coat' – and when he returns to the living room, 'which had suddenly changed, and taken the shape of my own everyday room', the anonymous man's attitude, too, has suddenly changed:

> Upon seeing me, he said: 'We came to an understanding.' 'Who with?' I asked. He laughed. 'The bird told me,' he said. I felt suddenly relieved. If the bird told him, it must have said good things … 'Did it tell you everything?' I said. 'It told me everything,' he said. I relaxed … 'In that case,' I said, 'there's nothing to be concerned about.' 'No,' he said. 'No, I'll just finish this cigarette and leave.' (118)

The narrative – and the book – concludes as the now-subdued bureaucrat leaves the domestic space:

> I no longer felt like going into the other room. I guessed that he would have long gotten up and left. Left through the window with the bird … The room I was in had warmed up a little. The stove was crackling loudly. I turned it down a bit. I went into the other room. I checked under the blanket. He was sound asleep, huddled up in a corner. I held him. The bird was flying from his head onto mine and from mine back onto his, again and again. Until morning I heard the beating of its wings, and his deep sleep. (119)

I quote and summarise the largely spatial twists and turns of this elegant, dreamlike narrative to show how the tensions and intertwinements between urban, natural, public, and private space that define *Alemdağ'da Var Bir Yılan* and its dialectic of queer space come to a head in the book's climactic conclusion. First the outside world – a bird, a walking tree, clouds, smoke, snow – comes pouring into the urban domestic environment, and unbuilt, natural space, celebrated earlier in the book as a friendly accomplice to queer intimacy, turns into a roaring, unpredictable menace. A freezing gale makes the domestic space uninhabitable, but at the same time instigates the narrator to seek the warmth and the nearness of the beloved; and we once again witness space and materiality serve as both roadblocks and instigators of queer being and intimacy. The beloved, in turn, is finally receptive towards the narrator-flaneur's affections in the rarest of moments; but only if the mystical bird – a segment of the natural environment in revolt – is also admitted into the most private of all spaces: the conjugal bedroom in a world freezing over. And yet, the narrator's movement out of the bedroom to retrieve the bird results in the beloved's disappearance into thin air, adding yet another to the flaneur-narrator's numerous missed encounters with Panco across the book — as if to assert that moving towards, and finally running into the beloved is always the prelude to walking away, to losing them to the world.

But a new, private-natural spatiality emerges as a synthesis of natural and domestic environments is attempted in the bringing of the bird into the most private of urban spaces. To remind ourselves:

> I left the bird on the nightstand. It began to chirp. This room was still warm, cozy. Still the curve of his lip and the thin hairless scar on his eyebrow crashed on my head like paper planes children make and throw around in class. (117)

In this new synthetic spatiality, the beloved's absence is not experienced as a ravenous emotional hollowness; but with warmth, fulfilment, and joy: as presence. He is, in the 'curve of his lip' and 'the thin hairless scar', 'not here but here'.

It is precisely the same bird – representative of the intertwinement of domestic-urban and natural space, of the latter's seeping into and blessing of the former – that intercedes for the narrator and the beloved shortly afterwards, when, in another sudden disruption of boundaries between public and private space, the Kafkaesque investigator enters the domestic space and begins his menacing investigation. This outside, indeed political or institutional, invasion of queer domestic space – of queer being and intimacy – ends only when nature itself attests, from *within* the private urban space it has been admitted into, to the 'good'ness of the intimacy between İshak and Panco. Remarkably, even as he stresses that the bird has 'told' the investigator 'everything', Abasıyanık refuses to offer this 'truth' in language: The potential, perils, and ultimate 'good'ness of queer being and intimacy are all expressed (in fact performed) in spatialised terms, as encounters in and with space. Navigating space – 'walking the path' – but also paying attention to the path, thinking about how the path can bridge not only two points but also different modes of experience in built and unbuilt space, is ultimately central to Abasıyanık's dialectic of queer space, and of being-in-space.

Concluding thoughts

Alemdağ'da Var Bir Yılan was an untimely book in more than one sense. When it was published in 1954, Turkish literature had not seen such an intricate – and ultimately, celebratory – representation of homoerotic intimacy and desire since the state-supported disappearance of Ottoman literary 'beloved's from the nineteenth century onwards (Andrews and Kalpaklı 2015, 304–329). Representation of queer being and desire would remain an infrequently-challenged taboo in Turkish literature for decades to come. *Alemdağ* itself would remain well-received but critically under-analysed, Abasıyanık's formally experimental, queer, and spatial concerns subsumed under a crude consensus on the 'surrealist' experimentalism of the book (Rifat 2020). In short, the book was not quite at home in its times, and perhaps neither was Abasıyanık, whose life, split between the island of Pyrgos/Burgazada off the coast of Istanbul and the still-predominantly Greek Istanbul quarter of Pera, combined the multiethnic spatial lexicon of the bygone Ottoman Empire with a (queer) libertinism that often puzzled his contemporaries.

On one last point – now that we have explored in full the complicated but ultimately tender relationship between İshak and Panco, – Abasıyanık's choice in *Alemdağ* to centre a 'beloved' belonging specifically to the Istanbul Greek community was arguably itself an act of political and literary subversion: The open inclusion of an Istanbul Greek youth as the nexus of desire and intimacy for Abasıyanık's autobiographical narrator – and, furthermore, Panco's centring as the deeply humane and tender narrator of a rather crucial narrative of the İshak-Panco saga – very obviously hearkens back to Istanbul as a space of lively if uneasy multiethnic coexistence. Much more importantly, however, Panco's humanising portrayal – and, critically, the ways in which the *intimacy* between İshak and Panco is shown to humanise *both* characters – amounts to a direct rejection of dominant political ideology and discourse in mid-twentieth century Republican Turkey, where Istanbul's Greek residents were systematically disenfranchised by the Turkish state and denigrated by the Turkish press. (Onayli 2024) This anti-Greek ideological stance, in fact, also extended into the realm of Republican-era literature well up to the time of *Alemdağ*'s writing, where Turkish authors portrayed Ottoman and post-

Ottoman Greeks overwhelmingly as untrustworthy amorals – and sexual deviants – not to be associated with (Millas 1996, idem. 1999). In a further intertwinement of anti-Greek sentiment and modern Turkish literature, multiple late Ottoman and early Republican authors, in condemning the widespread homoeroticism of the classical Ottoman literary tradition, did so precisely by portraying it as a lamentable and fundamentally Greek 'corruption' of Ottoman or Turkish values — Ömer Seyfettin, in one prominent example, in criticising overtly homoerotic classical Ottoman poets like Nedim and Fazıl Enderunî, lamented their '[literary] monuments the indecencies of which were made out of Byzantine sensibilities' (Seyfeddin 1911, 1–3), and Abdülbaki Gölpınarlı pondered whether the 'unnatural love' so prevalent in Ottoman poets first went 'from India to Persia to Hellas, or spread from Hellas to the world?' (Sarıtaş 2020, 45; quoting Gölpınarlı 1945, 30). Abasıyanık's romance of İshak and Panco, one could posit, flies in the face of such assertions of a fundamentally unnatural, alien, corrupting 'infiltration' of 'Greek' indecency not only by centring and affirming a Turkish narrator's 'Greek love' – felt towards an actual Greek, no less – but also by doing so through a recognisable rehabilitation of the long-condemned classical (and so-called 'Byzantine' or 'Helladic') socio-literary modes of Ottoman Istanbul.

Not to make banal historical and biographical inferences, it is hardly surprising that *Alemdağ*, Abasıyanık's literary last will and testament, written while the author knew he was mortally ill, leans as strongly as it does on spatiality. Its insistent, dialectical engagement with space and being-in-space allows the book to explore queer being and desire as fundamentally connected to the relationships between built/urban and unbuilt/natural space, an Ottoman (and indeed Greco-Persian) homoerotic literary legacy and Turkish modernity, and finally, between Istanbul's Turks and Greeks. Arguably, the turn to space also allows Abasıyanık to 'gum up' the present historical and cultural time: that is, to hold at bay, de-naturalise, and thus challenge dominant, 'timely' homophobic ideology; and to claim a counter-hegemonic cultural, literary, and political *space* for others to inhabit and expand. The present attempt to theorise *Alemdağ* represents one such attempt to understand that space and its potentialities. The path, of course, remains to be walked.

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